CHAPTER 15

# Troubleshooting and Debugging

Dot, dot, dot, dot, dot.

Tests are passing; looks like it's time for lunch.

Dot, dot, dot, dot, F.

F? F?

But the code works. I know it does.

I think it does.

Why is my test failing?

One of the most frustrating moments in the life of a TDD developer is when a test is failing and it's not clear why. In this chapter you'll look at tools you can use to diagnose failing tests to help improve your testing experience.

## General Principles

This may be the most obvious piece of advice in the book:

> **Prescription 40** When a formerly passing test fails, something has changed.

Obvious or not, it's worth repeating, mantra-like, when confronted with a bug. When a formerly passing test fails, it means something changed.

It may be in the code, in the system, or in the test. It may be that the time of day has changed. But it's probably not sunspots, and it's probably not evil spirits possessing your MacBook (unless you're living in one of Charles Stross's Laundry Files).